**SOCIETY & TRENDS** | Bright Young Indians

**SHOW AND TELL:** The art of self-belief, reading minds. And psychological illusion

**SUHANI SHAH** *Mentalist, Psychological illusionist*

# NOTHING'S RANDOM

**It took Suhani Shah all of 10 minutes** to blow everyone's minds at the India Today Conclave. Five people from the audience were randomly selected and brought on stage. Shah asked them to pick the seats they'd want to sit on and pick envelopes that had an emoji each. "You think everything is random. Nothing is random, ever," she said as she started. Then, during the session, she accurately went on to predict the emojis an audience member had on his mind and even told a few others the names of people they were thinking of. As she did so, there were notable sounds of "Whoa" and applause in the room. And that's how Shah demonstrated her art form "mentalism", which she says, has "nothing to do with *devi shakti* or superpowers".

Shah started at the young age of seven, beginning as 'Suhani the Jaadugar' (magician), doing stage shows across India. It was her parents who encouraged her to go beyond being the traditional magician seen at birthday parties. Today, Shah is one of the most followed mentalists on social media, whose inbox is flooded with requests as bizarre as revealing forgotten passwords or simple ones like reading someone's mind. ■



BANDEEP SINGH

**I do not read minds. I only give an illusion of reading minds**

**You think everything is random. Nothing is random, ever. We are here because of all the random decisions we have made**

We have given women enough messages already. It is important we give them opportunities now

## KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Mentalism is an art form and not some superpower
- When asked if she had any words of wisdom for girls and women, Shah said, "They are already very intelligent." Her only advice is for people not to suppress them, either in their neighbourhood or on the internet
- Magic is a parent category. Mentalism and illusion are genres within it